



XIII

Say Your Numbers

XIII derives its name and base from a famous French comic. You're a secret agent at the centre of a thick Web of deception. You've lost your precious memory, which also happens to be the catalyst of the plot. Steve Rowland, alias XIII, is the code name of the agent who has supposedly killed the President of the 'Free World', and who himself is presumed dead.

Almost everyone you meet, apart from the core team you're introduced to, is surprised at your survival... XIII starts off with you waking up on a desolate beach, with Roman numerals tattooed on your collarbone. Soon, you realise that a mysterious group, The Twenty, is after your blood. Like fish that don't smell too good, the plot twists and twirls, sucking the very marrow out of your bones.

With every little sensory message such as the sound of an old General's voice, etc, you get flashbacks of your rather unfortunate life. You remember eavesdropping on conversations in grim, grey scenarios. This convenient recollection is the sharp-edged hook of the game. XIII is action-packed from beginning to end, and has dramatically executed cutscenes that glue missions together cohesively.

Loads of missions with enough play-

time keep your itchy trigger-finger ticking. *The Unreal II* engine powers the cel-shaded delightful graphics, making XIII the first-ever FPS to have them. The AI though is predictable and the environment lacks enough interactivity. It's only in the beginning of the game, when your hands are empty, that you feel the need to pick up objects such as a chair, a bottle or an ashtray and knock some heads to gain guns and other deadly items.

XIII features visual sound, a special feature in comics. For example, a guard on the other side of the wall is traversing an area you need to pass. You can attach yourself to the adjacent wall and watch as a "Tap, Tap" text descends and ascends in size and distance according to his location.

Body animations are well drawn too, from the sensual pose of a medical nurse watching you flee for your life, to a manic doctor rampaging in rage towards you.

Whereas in other similarly themed games, you'd have one final mission with enough nightmare bots being thrown in to cause a massive system meltdown and enough stealth required to liquify bones,

XIII borrows from the 'main boss' concept. So, while in some cases you have a mad doctor waving a screen-bending drug in his hand, others are heavily armed hardcore militarists that require brawn and skill to defeat. They have one thing in common though—all are monstrous enough for you to replay and retry till you succeed.

The lead character's voice, rendered by David Duchovny, is rather subdued, and goes down well, giving it more dimension and depth.



How brown is my valley...

Rapper Eve plays Major Jones, and Adam West gives life to General Carrington. Sound effects develop tension at a steady pace. The weapons themselves are staple spy diet—you'll get crossbows for stealth missions, snipers, and an awful load of shotguns, AKs and M4s.

Load times, too, are a pain. The main installation itself occupies a generous chunk of space. And you need to juggle four CDs as and when the game demands them. The usual generic save system is replaced by a cumbersome checkpoints system that serve as starting points when you restart your game or fail in a mission.

The storyline draws inspiration from a variety of real-life circumstances. The presidential assassination scenario is all too Kennedy-ish. There are similarities in style and concept to other spy-thriller games such as *Splinter Cell*. XIII tries to strike a balance between being too brain-racking and overtly simple.

Like any half-baked product, XIII does have its juicy parts. Unfortunately, this is in no way a game that keeps you on the floor, on your knees, fists clenched, a tear rolling down your left cheek while doom metal plays thoughts of complete submission... no, it's not this one.



Walk straight and take the left to see Hell. You can't miss it

Genre: Action ■ Developer: Ubisoft ■ Publisher: Ubisoft ■ Distributor: NA

Phone: NA ■ E-mail: NA ■ System Requirements: 600 MHz CPU, 128 MB RAM, 16 MB 3D card ■ Price: NA

Web site: www.whoisxiii.com

Rating: ★★★★★☆